

Research Article

Conceptualizing the adventure tourist as a cross-boundary learner

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ABSTRACT

In recent years, the adventure tourism sector has seen new travelers seeking self-transformation, learning, and an expanded worldview rather than risk and thrill. They have attracted attention for their contribution to the local economies. However, their motivation behind seeking such goals through adventure tourism remains unknown. Therefore, this study proposes a hypothesis explaining their transformation. An explanatory hypothesis is that adventure tourists possess the evaluation axis of cross-boundary learners who discover new selves through serendipitous encounters and events. Cross-boundary learning, a part of organizational learning, can be conceptually identified with planned happenstance theory (psychology) and effectuation theory (management) that locates self-transformation source in given non-cognitive abilities. Also, adventure tourists have an “ambivalent value” allowing them to simultaneously evaluate the exploitation of knowledge from the service-scape and the exploration of knowledge from the ethnoscape. This conceptual model thus bridges theory and practice for the development of the adventure tourism industry.

Management implications: The findings of this study can be summarized as follows.

- Adventure tourists have ambivalent values of knowledge exploration and exploitation;
- They become adventure tourists when they incidentally encounter ethnoscape that are specific to and still rooted in the region of their travel destination; and
- What makes them adventure tourists is a cross-boundary learning mindset, which can be confirmed by measuring their non-cognitive abilities.

Based on the above, the management implications are that adventure tourism operators should.

- Focus their attention not only on the sophistication of their services, but also on preserving the ethnoscape of the business area; and
- Plan for the generation of communities of practice in destinations that facilitate cross-boundary learning including knowledge exploration and exploitation by travelers.

1. Background

Adventure tourism, which offers a major contribution to the local economy through small group, high-value tourism combined with low impact on the regional community and environment, has been gaining significant attention in recent times. According to estimates from the Adventure Travel Trade Association (ATTA, 2021), it takes only four adventure tourists to generate 10,000 USD for the local economy, whereas conventional overnight-package tourists would require nine individuals. There exist various definitions of adventure tourism. Danger

used to be a feature of adventure tourism, as in Meier (1978), who emphasized physical danger, and Hall (1992), who interpreted it as risk perceived and controlled by the expertise of an operator. A study conducted by Sand and Gross (2019) examined previous definitions and pointed out that risk and uncertainty have been central themes in the existing literature (Ewert, 1989; Rantala et al., 2016). Thrill is the artistic commodification of the fear that this risk brings (Cater, 2006). The emphasis on risk stems from the understanding that the combination of excitement and the state of flow, known as the “rush,” has been identified as the source attracting individuals to engage in adventure

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activities (Buckley, 2012). Hence, the three elements of adventure tourism identified by Weaver (2001), namely, risk, physical fatigue, and specific skills, remain applicable even today.

However, the World Tourism Organization (2014) adheres to a definition different from the above-mentioned perspective that includes elements of risk and thrill. Instead, it follows ATTA's definition, which defines a trip as one that incorporates at least two of these three elements: physical activity, natural environment, and cultural immersion. This activity includes experiences known as "soft adventure," which do not require elements of risk, physical fatigue, or specific skills (such as culinary classes and traditional food tastings in varied cultural contexts) (ATTA, 2018a). One of the surveys supporting this new definition targeted North American adventure travelers, revealing that their motivations were more strongly oriented toward "transformation," "learning," and "expanded worldview" rather than the elements of risk and thrill (Viren et al., 2017). Similarly, there is a form of adventure tourism known as "slow adventure," which places emphasis on deep and immersive experiences without requiring extensive skills or challenges. Reports of this type of adventure tourism have been particularly centered around Nordic countries (Varley & Semple, 2015). For example, Farkic et al. (2022) suggested that guided, slow adventures contribute to psychological, physical, and social wellbeing for tourists seeking softer and simplified outdoor experiences. "The breadth of adventure tourism is large and presents challenges for definitive definition" (Jenkins, 2019, p.4) because of the emergence of these new adventure. More than ever before, it has become difficult to define adventure tourism.

The deviation from the traditional perception of adventure tourists as primarily seeking risk and thrill has, in fact, been recognized as early as Sung et al. (1996). This research study focused on operators participating in adventure trade shows and found that the most significant aspect valued by customers is the activity itself, whereas interest in risk is relatively low. It became evident from this study that, business operators had begun to realize empirically that being excessively risky was no longer a crucial value for their customers. In the field of tourism psychology, which focuses on the motivations of adventure tourists, there has been a recent increase in surveys looking beyond the rush element. For instance, research conducted by Schneider and Vogt (2012) examined the comparison between hard adventure travelers and soft adventure travelers, with a specific emphasis on personality traits. This study revealed that the former group exhibited a higher need for arousal, whereas the latter group demonstrated a greater interest in cultural experiences and competitiveness, thus indicating that adventure tourists seek various aspects beyond the rush element. Studies have also revealed that hikers, as adventure travelers, have a higher motivation for learning than ordinary tourists (Du et al., 2016). Interest in culture and learning was also strongly suggested in the emotional profile survey of adventure travelers conducted by Viren et al. (2017), as mentioned earlier. Studying the history of adventure tourism research, Rantala et al. (2016) described how these adventure tourists' motivations tend to be intrinsic, like an inner journey. This inner journey, Varley and Taylor (2013) suggest, is the binding element that links adventure tourism as commerce and adventure education, which includes the learning component described above. In this paper, the new form of adventure tourism, which includes learning and cultural elements, is termed "inner journey," distinct from traditional adventure tourism, known for its risk and thrill elements.

According to Vargo and Lusch's (2004, 2008) "service-dominant logic," widely recognized in the business field, customers have been regarded as co-creators of value, and companies are responsible for offering value propositions. This perspective justifies the shift from the conventional definition, derived inductively from service providers, to the current definition, based on the changing preferences of customers. Whether the observable phenomenon is cultural tourism, sports tourism, or eco-tourism, a certain number of inner journeyers will blend in. In marketing, it is more important to define the adventure tourist based on

their values than on the definition of tourism. Therefore, this study will take the three values of the new adventure tourist (self-transformation, learning, and expansion of worldview) indicated by Viren et al. (2017) as clues to reveal essentially who they are. The reason for relying on this study is not only that it demonstrates the transformation of adventure tourists. These three values could be a priori, since they are widely available as ATTA media fact sheet (ATTA, 2018b), along with the definition of adventure tourism mentioned at the beginning of this article. Therefore, it is urgently necessary to identify those who have these values and to consider the applicability of these values in practice based on their customer profile. These values cannot be satisfied by offering activities that are objectively considered adventurous, such as hard adventure with an element of risk and thrill. This complicates the process of conducting motivational surveys on destination marketing. Such surveys are not deficient in objective adventure elements but rather in new self-discovery aspects, thereby making it difficult for the person in question to verbalize specific push motivations. Tracer (2006) attempted to classify adventure tourists into four quadrants based on multiplying pull factors (product attributes based on risk) and push factors (individual attributes based on knowledge and skills). As segmentation based on these tangible attributes is becoming more difficult and since more psychographic segmentation is required for inner journeyers, as described below, there is a need to reassess who adventure tourists are.

According to a report by the International Finance Corporation & Adventure Travel Trade Association (2019), based on a survey of adventure travelers in the United States and Australia, the customer profile of adventure tourists could be classified into three categories: adventure intensive, experience sampler, and cultural explorer. Among these, the experience sampler segment is considered the most high-end group. They are typically young, affluent individuals who enjoy challenges regardless of whether they engage in hard or soft adventure activities. They prefer spontaneous planning, often making travel arrangements in relatively short periods. For them, "friends and family" serve as the primary sources of travel information and inspiration for their trips (International Finance Corporation & Adventure Travel Trade Association, 2019). Hence, inquiring about destination-specific pull motivations might lead to post-hoc responses, making it potentially difficult to obtain precise answers from them. There is a view that the internal transformation caused by travel is not always a motivation, but occurs after the journey as an unexpected consequence of travel in the first place (Sheldon, 2020).

This paper aims to establish an explanatory hypothesis that theoretically redefines the adventure tourist, who has become elusive due to his or her deviation from risk and thrill. The social significance of this study lies in presenting a conceptual model derived from an established hypothesis that can be utilized for destination marketing. As Buckley (2014) mentioned, research on adventure tourists is not only confined to the realm of social psychology, which aims to empirically reveal the motivations mentioned above, but is also expanding into other academic fields. Indeed, with the emergence of new adventure tourists who are moving away from traditional rush-oriented experiences and embarking on inner journeys of self-reflection, it becomes appropriate to explore theories from other academic disciplines to explain the mechanisms driving their self-transformation. Specifically, the paper explores three directions mentioned earlier: "self-transformation," "learning," and "expanded worldview." This is the suggestive phase that examines the theories that can explain the inner journey of adventure tourists from each of these perspectives. By consolidating these theories, the paper develops an explanatory hypothesis for a more principle conceptual model representing new adventure tourists. The consolidation is discussed with an aim to attain verifiability following the "middle-range theories" proposed by Merton (1968), which bridge the gap between theory and practice (empirical science) and contribute to social development. The paper ends by suggesting directions for future research in terms of its verifiability.

2. Theoretical frameworks: suggestive phase

2.1. Theories on “self-transformation” of tourists

According to Viren et al. (2017), “transformation” refers to the process of self-change, characterized by personal growth, facing challenges, and achieving goals. In the field of anthropological tourism, which explores how human beings experience tourism phenomena, the existence of such self-transformative travelers has been a subject of discussion since early times. Graburn (1977), drawing upon van Gennep’s (1909/1960) concept of the “rites of passage,” viewed the spatial and temporal aspects of tourism as transitions and liminal zones (liminality), while considering travel as an extraordinary space. He viewed tourism as a space of encounter between human beings who have detached themselves from their origins, status, and position. He argued that, after returning home, their status and condition are renewed like those of newcomers who have completed the rites of passage and are welcomed into a new life. However, the rites of passage theory has had its critics, such as Boorstin (1964), who viewed tourists as merely individuals enjoying pseudo-events meticulously crafted by travel agencies, events lacking spontaneity and authenticity. MacCannell (1976/1999) shared a similar perspective, suggesting that tourists are not satisfied with pseudo-events as customers but rather seek to peek “back stage” as described by Goffman (1959/1974). However, the conclusion is that they encounter staged authenticity rather than genuine authenticity.

However, some argue that authenticity itself is not a singular concept. Wang (1999) categorized authenticity into three types and referred to MacCannell’s notion of being unable to reach true authenticity as “objective authenticity.” In contrast, “constructive authenticity” suggests that authenticity depends on the beliefs and practices of the actors involved in tourism activity. According to Wang, what is most important for tourists is “existential authenticity,” wherein tourists can experience themselves as their true selves through tourism, rather than focusing solely on the authenticity of the tourist attraction as an attribute. Therefore, Wang stated that van Gennep’s rites of passage, which has been present in the field of anthropological tourism from its early stages, remains relevant, and in liminality, tourists can establish authentic relationships. With the COVID-19 pandemic making it impossible to travel far, a return to the core of what adventure is about was seen in micro-adventures, from the existing adventure travel of going further and faster to going deeper (Mackenzie & Goodnow, 2020). Mackenzie and Goodnow (2020) explained that liminality is not diminished in the context of these micro adventures, which Humphreys (2014) defined as short-term adventures completed close to home in normal places for normal people. It is a concept that can explain contemporary adventure.

The debate on authenticity among tourists has also influenced phenomenological sociology. Cohen (1979) classified tourists into five modes based on their varied perspectives on authenticity. He referred to travelers who seek authenticity in intangible cultures and values as being in the “experimental mode” and “existential mode.” Individuals in these modes are travelers who engage in self-transformation by not adhering rigidly to their own center (the cultural and religious values that form the basis of personality development, as described by Cohen) and, instead, move closer to or even adopt the centers of others. They seek personal growth and change through their travel experiences. Cohen’s tourist experience theory may explain contemporary adventure tourists, who are travelers seeking self-transformation.

Cohen’s approach is sociological. From a different perspective, tourism sociology explores how tourism phenomena are generated through the interactions of various stakeholders, such as guests, hosts, and producers who stand as intermediaries. Urry and Larsen (2011) argued for the concept of “performance turn” in tourism, wherein tourists are not merely passive observers but prosumers who engage in performative acts during their travel experiences. In particular, in

today’s highly mobile society, the roles of hosts and guests in tourism have become increasingly fluid. In the context of the complex and blurred distinctions between tourist destinations and non-tourist places as well as between ordinary and extraordinary experiences in contemporary society, the concept of identity reconstitution assumes a relevance going beyond the boundaries of tourism destinations. This complex and blurred state of tourism is explained by the concept of “reflexivity” advocated by Giddens (1992). According to Beck et al. (1994), reflexivity refers to a situation wherein knowledge and perceptions of a particular autopoietic phenomenon return to influence that phenomenon. For example, as Urry and Larsen (2011) pointed out through the “collective gaze” concept, the presence of several other tourists watching a carnival can create a carnival-like atmosphere in that place. Indeed, in recent years, this reflexivity has become more prevalent in the field of tourism, blurring the distinction between “authentic” and “inauthentic” cultural experiences. Tourism sociology has identified “tourists observing tourists” and their focus on how tourism “comes back to me” rather than just “going” on a journey, which aligns with the concept of self-seeking adventure tourists. Thus, the presence of self-transformative travelers has been discussed early on from a relativistic perspective.

The exploration of specific pathways to self-transformation has been pursued within the domain of tourism psychology. As mentioned in Section 1, the focus on unraveling travelers’ motivations is a central research area in tourism psychology. Notably, the “travel career ladder” (TCL) model given by Pearce (1998) has gained prominence in the study of tourist motivations. This model posits that motivations evolve and become more proficient, akin to a career, through the accumulation of travel experiences, ultimately culminating in a desire for self-transformation referred to as “fulfillment” (for example, understanding oneself at a deeper level). However, the TCL model lacks sufficient empirical substantiation (Pearce & Lee, 2005). Moreover the “hierarchy of needs” given by Maslow (1967), which is the background to TCL, has rarely been referred to as a basic theory because it is conceptual and lacks empirical validity. However, Alderfer’s (1969) “existence, relatedness, and growth” (ERG) theory reconstructed the hierarchy of needs into three levels of needs: “existence,” “relatedness,” and “growth.” It found that the behaviors to satisfy these needs are not only manifested in ascending order, but can occur simultaneously. In other words, travelers’ behavior is not necessarily tied to a specific hierarchy of needs. Hence, it cannot be deduced from the behavior whether the traveler has reached self-transformation or not.

The behavioral theory in psychology analyzes human behavior in terms of current environment and past factors rather than motivation. In particular, in this sphere, we would like to focus on the “planned happenstance theory” given by Krumboltz (1996) as a theory that can explain the characteristics of adventure tourists. This theory generalizes the behavioral traits of people who consider themselves lucky. It suggests that those who are fortunate enough to have a new career possess five skills (curiosity, persistence, risk-taking, optimism, and flexibility). The term “lucky” refers to the fact that the content of the encounter was not set as a goal but left to contingency, but the contingency itself was planned as a result of the person’s behavioral characteristics. This theory can explain the characteristics of tourists who do not take time to plan their trips and act anyway. The five skills described by Krumboltz fall under meta-cognitive skills and social and emotional skills (collectively referred to hereafter as “non-cognitive abilities”), which constitute skills: one of the three elements that form competencies (knowledge, skills, as well as attitude and value) in Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) (2018). At a time when soft and slow adventures that do not require special knowledge or physical and practical skills are becoming more popular, Krumboltz’s perspective on the relationship between non-cognitive abilities and behavioral characteristics is thought-provoking. This suggests that, rather than every traveler going through rites of passage or an inner journey of reflexivity, such experiences might occur only for those possessing certain

non-cognitive abilities. For example, [Doran and Pomfret \(2019\)](#) focused on self-efficacy as a non-cognitive ability and stated that a high level of self-efficacy leads to negotiations that reduce personal constraints influencing motivation for adventure travel.

2.2. Theories on “learning” of tourists

“Learning” in [Viren et al. \(2017\)](#) referred to the acquisition of wisdom, insight, and an enriching experience, not just knowledge and skills. Learning through adventure has been a subject of exploration within the field of education, particularly in disciplines such as adventure education and outdoor education. As [Giddy and Webb \(2016\)](#) described, [Csikszentmihalyi's \(1974\)](#) flow experience is important in the risk- and thrill-seeking state of mind in traditional adventure tourism. The concept of flow has also been significant in the realm of adventure education, where it is often emphasized as “peak adventure” ([Ingman, 2017](#)). Both concepts emphasize the importance of the instructor's control of the balance between competence and risk for participants to escape their comfort zones and grow and learn; this has become established as “learning zone model” for facilitating the attainment of learning ([Senninger, 2000](#)). However, in the context of adventure education, as described by [Mortlock \(1984\)](#), adventure experiences are premised on developing and gaining vitality within the relationship with the natural environment. On the other hand, in the realm of adventure tourism, with the emergence of soft adventures, such experiences can exist even in the absence of natural elements. As highlighted by [Large and Schilar \(2018\)](#), elements of adventure are spatially and temporally subjective, carrying meaning primarily within the context of an individual's life story. The outdoor setting and the inherent natural risks (elements of thrill) serve only as facilitators inducing the state of flow. Owing to these distinctions, it is not feasible to simply discuss the learning of new adventure tourists within the framework of adventure education models.

Turning to andragogy, [Tomljenovic and Ateljevic \(2015\)](#) noted that much of the literature on transformation in tourism relies on [Mezirow's \(1996, 2012\)](#) transformational learning theory. Transformational learning emphasizes learning how to transform one's mindset through critical reflection, a non-cognitive ability. Some researchers, such as [Ross \(2010\)](#), who see tourists as motivated and intent on self-transformation, rely on this theory. However, [Lean \(2009\)](#) stated that there is no empirical evidence that the motivation to travel leads to self-transformation and that it is not possible to determine when the transformation will occur. Even researchers in transformative learning, such as [Alhadeff-Jones \(2012\)](#), do not deny that disorienting dilemmas (such as the culture shock experienced by adventure tourists, referred to as such in the transformative learning literature) are a trigger, but state that self-transformation is an uncontrollable process. A different perspective may be needed to explain the learning of adventure tourists.

As [Walsh and Golins \(1976\)](#) stated, Adventure education as described above is also an area that has evolved from the initial model of “experiential learning” given [Kolb et al. \(1971\)](#). The learning sought by adventure tourists, on the other hand, is closer to the “unlearning” advocated by [Hedberg \(1981\)](#) than to the development of being able to do something by gaining experience. Unlearning is not learning for growth and development that aims at gaining experience and becoming able to do something, as in experiential learning by [Kolb \(1984\)](#). Rather, it aims for transformation by resetting accumulated experience ([O'Reilly, 2018](#)).

Unlearning has been discussed in the management discipline. The concepts of “new combination” and “discontinuous innovation,” as articulated by [Schumpeter \(1934\)](#), refer to the creation of new markets through the introduction of novel technologies or services diverging from the existing norms. This stands in contrast to continuous innovation, which involves refining existing products or services. In the context of this juxtaposition, these concepts are closely linked to the notions of “exploration” of knowledge (hereinafter referred to exploration) and

“exploitation” of knowledge (hereinafter referred to exploitation). [March \(1991\)](#) argued that relying solely on exploitation, which involves utilizing existing knowledge without sufficient exploration, may lead to short-term rationality but could result in the depletion of innovation in the medium to long term. He termed this phenomenon the “competency trap.” The concepts of exploration and exploitation bear similarities to the distinction between unlearning and experiential learning. However, in the realm of management studies, particularly in the context of avoiding the competency trap and path dependence, there is a stronger emphasis on viewing the failure to embrace change as a risk. Therefore, in addition to continuous growth, there is a need to pursue discontinuous innovation and foster the creation of new ventures. Thus, entrepreneurship, which represents the mindset for generating new business endeavors, has become an essential and indispensable field of research.

The elucidation of this entrepreneurial mindset was exemplified by [Sarasvathy \(2008\)](#) through her study of Silicon Valley entrepreneurs, wherein she presented “effectuation.” In this theory, she identifies the following characteristics of entrepreneurs: they start with unpredictable conditions rather than with a goal in mind, they prefer co-creation and interaction, and they take advantage of the contingency of unpredictable situations. For those with an entrepreneurial mindset, doing nothing is risky; hence, they act in the face of uncertainty. This is analogous to the experience sampler's behavior of not planning carefully. When viewed through the lens of “prospect theory,” as expounded by [Kahneman and Tversky \(1988\)](#) to explain an individual's aversion to uncertain situations, the behavior of adventure tourists embarking on trips without extensive destination research might appear risky. However, within the framework of an entrepreneur's risk perception, the mere act of doing something can itself be seen as risk-averse, thereby highlighting their approach.

The discipline of organizational learning explores concrete ways to implement this exploration and exploitation of knowledge through co-creation as organization. In organizational learning, a concept similar to unlearning is “cross-boundary learning”; however, it is strictly distinct. Boundary crossing in educational science is ongoing learning, wherein interaction occurs on both sides; this occurs not only in individual activities but also in social activities ([Akkerman & Bakker, 2011](#)). This resembles the relationship between tourists and tourist destinations. Unlearning, on the other hand, also occurs in transfer studies, such as personal activities where only one party moves and learns something new. For example, organizational resocialization (learning that occurs in the process of re-entering a new organization, for example, by changing jobs), as advocated by [Ashforth et al. \(2007\)](#), requires unlearning to dismiss the past in interpersonal relationships, values, and organizational politics ([Becker & Bish, 2021](#)). [Engestroem \(1987, 1995\)](#) used the term “vertical learning” and “horizontal learning” to describe the importance of horizontal learning in today's highly uncertain world. This horizontal learning is exploration, a concept that leads to what [Arthur \(1994\)](#) describes as a “boundaryless career,” that is, an individual who is oriented towards building his or her own career and abilities while transcending organizational boundaries. [Lave \(1988\)](#) further explained that learning does not take place in a classroom setting that ignores the context of everyday life, but in “communities of practice.” In other words, cross-boundary learning is a state of collaborative learning in other communities of practice or an interactive state in a boundaryless career, as shown in [Fig. 1](#) below.

[Sheldon \(2020\)](#), referring to the work of [Soulard et al. \(2019\)](#), pointed out that for the host side to bring about self-transformation in a tourist, it is important to integrate the unique local culture and desires of the host communities into the tourists' experience by building this “communities of practice”. She also explained that the employees on the host side are the ones who can co-create the tourist's experience of self-transformation by building bridges with different cultures that lead to self-transformation ([Sheldon, 2020](#)). This is as opposed to learning at home or at work, alone or with monotonous peers. It is suggested that the “inner journey” can be designed by shifting the perspective from

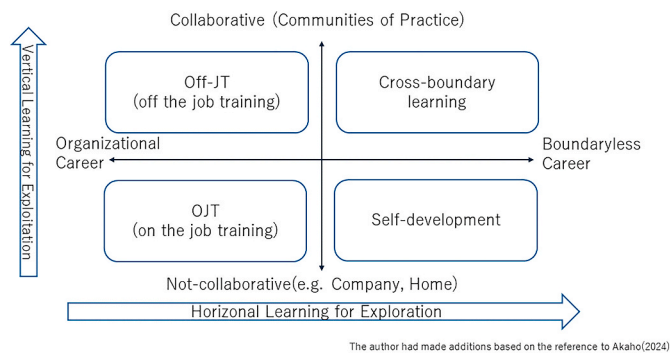


Fig. 1. Positioning map of cross-boundary learning.

transformational learning to cross-boundary learning (Akaho, 2024).

In summary, adventure education, which has evolved in the field of pedagogy, may not fully represent the new generation of adventure tourists due to its emphasis on outdoor experiences and its reliance on experiential learning models. Instead, concepts such as unlearning, which are discussed in the field of management, seem to align more closely with their learning approaches. This is because unlearning, which involves exploration to avoid the competency trap or to foster discontinuous innovation, is relevant. The mindset of entrepreneurs, as demonstrated by the effectuation and the practice of cross-boundary learning within groups for collaborative exploration and exploitation, are potential hypotheses that can explain the “learning” of adventure tourists.

2.3. Theories on “expanded worldview” of tourists

The “expanded worldview” in the study by Viren et al. (2017) refers to the desire for an indigenous culture, such as exposure to varied cultures/histories and tolerance as well as a broadened perspective. This involves a change in taste and preference, which has been studied in cultural sociology. Non-cognitive abilities in Section 2.1 are called “habitus” in cultural sociology. Habitus is the persistent disposition underlying our actions: the system of dispositions that directs our various actions (Bourdieu, 1979/1984).

Habitus is posited to determine preferences and inclinations within social classes; this concept is referred to as “cultural reproduction theory.” Bourdieu (1986) asserted that the cultural capital shaping habitus is influenced by the cultural environment of one’s upbringing. This inheritance of cultural capital forms habitus, which in turn shapes preferences and inclinations, thus manifesting as a process of cultural reproduction. When Bourdieu discussed taste, he operated under the assumption of a class-based society, emphasizing antipathy toward others’ preferences and aesthetic intolerance (Bourdieu, 1979/1984). However, insights from Peterson (1992) as also Peterson and Kern (1996) emerged from their investigation in the United States, introducing the concept of “cultural omnivores,” which denotes individuals who appreciate both mass and highbrow culture, coinciding with the rise of the middle class. This notion underwent successive examinations (Bryson, 1996; DiMaggio & Mukhtar, 2004; National Endowment for the Arts (NEA), 2005; NEA, 2009). In essence, contemporary tastes no longer exhibit cultural exclusivity but rather signify cultural tolerance, as described by Bryson as “broad taste.”

This shift can be attributed to the heightened interest and curiosity towards diverse cultures among highly educated and affluent adventure tourists. For instance, Kataoka’s (2000) study in Japan demonstrates the phenomenon of cultural omnivores. The research study confirms a positive correlation between factors such as higher income, educational attainment, occupational prestige and the abundance of inherited cultural capital with cultural tolerance (as indicated by broad taste). Notably, in this study, the younger generations exhibited a greater

inclination towards cultural tolerance.

Further, Lahire (2012/2016) advanced a theory, which posits that habitus formed by actors’ pasts translates into observable practices in the current contexts. In this framework, the term “context” refers to the domains or “fields”: where cultural capital can be manifested, including educational institutions, workplaces, and travel destinations (Trizzulla et al., 2016). In other words, the transformation of adventure tourists into an observable practice is not only because they have an embodied habitus of the past (or cultural tolerance in the present day), but also because adventure tourism contains the environment (fields) wherein they can demonstrate this habitus. Lahire’s (2012/2016) viewpoint, which is consistent with Sen’s argument in welfare economics, is that it is not enough for a person to have the ability to expand his or her worldview; it is also necessary to have fields to draw out that ability.

Freedom is not only access to goods, but also the ability to use them (education and knowledge), and a person with this ability is a person with high “capability” as espoused by Sen (1985). It is worth noting that considering capability means rethinking the “affordance” and “effectivity” of adventure tourists in the field of tourism. Affordance, as advocated by Gibson (1979), refers to the possibilities for action that the environment offer to perceivers/actors. Effectivity is an attribute of the perceiver/actor, which enables them to perceive affordances and perform actions. According to Vaz et al. (2017), it cannot be demonstrated as a capability unless it fits with affordance. To put it in the context of adventure tourism, the expression would be that the mountain (environment) affords you (aware that you have sufficient physical strength and knowledge skills) the opportunity to climb it. The adventure is your adventure with a particular effectivity, but it is neither active nor passive; it is the result of the interaction between the individual and the environment.

In the context of recurring tourism and performance inversion discussed within the disciplines of tourism anthropology and tourism sociology, the psychobiological perspective inherent in welfare economics, specifically the concept of affordances influencing effectivities and vice versa, offers valuable insights. This cyclical structure of affordance shaping effectivity and effectivity influencing affordance can guide us away from a binary perspective of whether to observe tourism phenomena or to be observed by them.

From the above discussion, it can be inferred that the concept of cultural omnivore can elucidate the interest of adventure tourists in varied cultures. Further, the notion of customers’ habitus (effectivity) and the contexts wherein they can be manifested (affordance) can provide an explanatory framework for the process by which adventure tourists, as capability, manifest the expansion of their worldview.

3. Discussion: deliberative phase

3.1. Explanatory hypothesis

In this section, we will enter the deliberative phase of choosing from the various theories. The theories of “rites of passage” and “reflexivity” provide a clear explanation of the reality of adventure travelers. However, they face challenges in terms of “verifiability.” It is difficult to quantitatively determine the extent to which they align or deviate from empirical facts, making verification complex. In particular, for travelers in the experimental mode, as outlined by Cohen (1979), they might not fully understand what they are seeking, they might lack awareness of their true desires and wishes, and their journeys could be seen as fundamentally religious inquiries, even though the destination remains vaguely defined. This notion aligns with the concept of a “decentered personality” characterized by individuals who possess these traits. This portrayal captures the elusive motivations of contemporary adventure tourists and appears to fulfill the plausibility. However, it also faces challenges in terms of verifiability. This mode is distinguished by the degree of proximity or detachment from one’s spiritual center. This spiritual center is a conceptual notion, and the measurement of

proximity or detachment lacks uniformity. The extent to which tourism activities deviate from this center, the baseline for the decentered individual, is ambiguous. Consequently, the identification of this deviation through means such as questionnaires or interviews becomes difficult, making disconfirmation problematic.

On the other hand, within the discipline of education, concepts such as “unlearning,” and in the realm of psychology, the “planned happenstance theory,” excel in terms of verifiability. Both approaches emphasize non-cognitive abilities that contribute to an individual’s competency, and this advantage stems from the existence of well-developed measurement scales. For instance, curiosity can be measured using the “five-dimension curiosity scale” (Kashdan et al., 2020), optimism through the “revised life orientation test” (Scheier et al., 1994), and empathy using the “interpersonal reactivity index” (Davis, 1983). Further, unlearning is tied to the necessity of exploration for avoiding the “competency trap,” particularly in cases of “organizational resocialization” and “cross-boundary learning.” The former is a one-time transfer study and remains individualistic, whereas the latter is interactive and affects social activities. The perspective of avoiding the competency trap by exploring knowledge not only through experiential (vertical) learning but also through unlearning (horizontal) can be represented with reference to the figure of discontinuous innovation by Chen and Yin (2019), as shown in Fig. 2 below.

The concept of exploration exists across the development of individuals and the development of organizations composed of those individuals, but both phenomena involve cross-boundary learning, as shown in Fig. 1. In addition, since the proportion of non-cognitive abilities does not change with the situation, there is no need to distinguish between business people and adventure tourists as far as this is concerned.

Focusing on the similarities between the mindset of entrepreneurs who actively engage in unlearning to create new businesses and the orientation of adventure tourists, Fig. 2 shows the state in which contingency leads to growth and change, based on “effectuation.” Therefore, the following hypothesis can be generated, while covering the concepts within each discipline.

Explanatory hypothesis:

The adventure tourist is inherently an unlearner. If this is true, then it is only natural that adventure tourists seek to learn from contingencies and to transform themselves.

3.2. Conceptual model and modified explanatory hypothesis

Although the explanatory hypotheses are based on Fig. 2, there is one point that must be kept in mind. That is, exploration does not always follow exploitation. Cross-boundary learning is a concept that includes both, as shown in Fig. 1. In addition, the ERG theory states that the

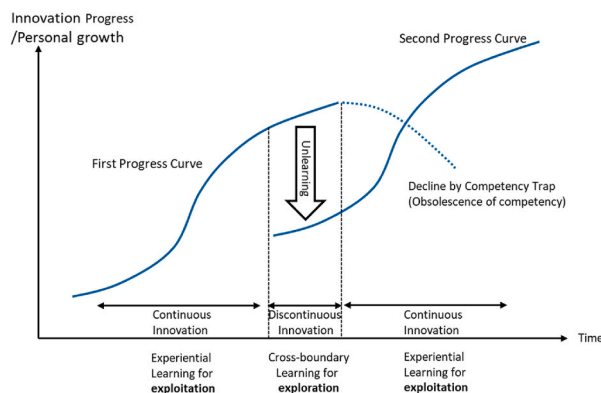
desire for self-transformation can occur simultaneously along with other desires. Further, the cultural omnivore perspective suggests that they do not “only” seek self-transformation nor do they “always” seek to move out of their comfort zones.

The experience sampler has an eudaimonic consumption tendency, which involves efforts to move out of the comfort zone for the benefits of local travel despite using the comfort vehicle (first class or business class) when traveling to the destination (International Finance Corporation & Adventure Travel Trade Association, 2019). In essence, following Lahire’s (2012/2016) theory, the most plausible hypothesis is that individuals “become” adventure travelers when they encounter contexts allowing them to manifest their non-cognitive abilities. This aligns with the notion that they “become” such travelers in circumstances wherein they can effectively showcase their capabilities. This context is culture, but the authenticity of that culture is existential authenticity, that is, “cultural activities more frequent in their daily lives” (International Finance Corporation & Adventure Travel Trade Association, 2019, p.21). It is an authenticity that allows people to learn and reflect upon themselves, based on the everyday life of the country they accidentally encounter rather than from a prepared cultural experience.

This everyday situation is termed as “ethnoscape,” which differs from “landscape” or “servicescape.” Servicescape is a physical environment created by the business side, including interior and exterior design, atmosphere, and social factors, so that interactions between sellers and buyers might occur (Bitner, 1992; Booms & Bitner, 1981). Ethnoscapes, on the other hand, have emerged as a new, non-traditional landscape of life created by the activities of immigrants, asylum seekers, refugees, foreign workers, travelers, and others amid globalization (Appadurai, 1996). However, in this study, ethnoscape is used in the sense of “everyday landscapes that are unique to the region and still rooted in the region” and linked to their interests, namely, the tradition of indigenous cultural communities and cultural immersion, as suggested by Viren et al. (2017) in their emotional profile of adventure travelers. It is not a programmed cultural resource, as in a museum, or a cultural resource whose objective authenticity is explained, but a pre-servicization form of what might be described as a slice of daily life.

Based on the aforementioned discussion, if I were to conceptually depict the adventure tourist, it could be illustrated as shown in Fig. 3. Just as the relationship between supply and demand or the growth of individuals is typically represented by curves, I too have temporarily represented the same using curves. The key point is the inherent “ambivalent value” of the cross-boundary learner, wherein both experiential learning (exploitation) and unlearning (exploration) are valued experiences, not a sequential process. They can evaluate the practice of service excellence, as outlined in ISO 23592 and ISO/TS 24082, which are standards being considered for service excellence standardization. Simultaneously, they can also attribute high evaluations to everyday aspects of non-service-oriented destinations. To use an analogy with regard to the accommodation business, they can appreciate the hotelier at a five-star luxury hotel in an urban area and simultaneously appreciate the local lodge-owner who would drink with the climbers.

Service value for customers is generally expressed at four levels: basic, expected, desired, and unanticipated, as described by Albrecht (1992). Currently, it is expressed in the form of Kauman’s (2002) six levels: criminal, basic, expected, desired, surprising, and unbelievable. In the paradigm of achieving high added value through the pursuit of excellent service, one progresses through these stages sequentially. However, for the new adventure tourists, the sequence is different. In the context of everyday life, before the advent of service orientation, they encounter an unanticipated ethnoscape referred to as “criminal service,” which is often perceived as negative. Subsequently, they recognize the landscape as “desired service” and even progress to “surprising service” or beyond, for instance, “unbelievable service.” Fig. 3 illustrates the unique customer profile that emerges as they perceive these various levels of service amidst their ethnoscape encounters.



The author has made additions based on the reference to Chen and Yin (2019)

Fig. 2. Relevance of innovation and unlearning.

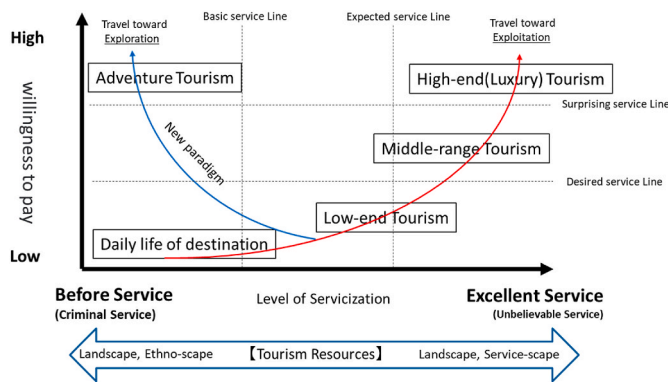


Fig. 3. Conceptual model of the ambivalent value of adventure tourists.

Fig. 3 represents an ambivalent smile curve that manifests only for those who can be afforded by the ethnoscares and exert effectivity from them. Therefore, the explanatory hypothesis can be modified as follows: Modified explanatory hypothesis:

The adventure tourist is an inherently cross-boundary learner. If this is true, then it is only natural that adventure tourists can inherently extract learning and self-transformation from contingencies.

In case of entrepreneurs who favor cross-boundary learning, a distinguishing trait that sets them apart from others could be the degree of openness, as proposed by Goldberg (1992) in the Big Five personality traits (Wang et al., 2016; Zhao et al., 2010; Zhao & Seibert, 2006). Since openness is characterized by curiosity and optimism, the measurement of these non-cognitive abilities can be used to verify whether people have an entrepreneurial mindset favoring cross-boundary learning. Matsuo (2019) found that unlearning requires critical reflection (learning orientation), as part of a study conducted in the United States. Hence, the critical thinking of adventure tourists can be validated through the application of a constructed measurement scale [for example, the Cornell Critical Thinking Test by Ennis (1985)]. Through such operational definitions, it becomes possible to verify and potentially refute explanatory hypotheses by comparing the identified criteria with the non-cognitive abilities of other tourists.

Habitus referred to in cultural sociology, resembles non-cognitive abilities. However, its measurement is possible if the researcher creates questions that recall inherited cultural capital, such as childhood upbringing. This theory has not been adopted as an explanatory hypothesis, because it is not in line with the scope of this study that focuses on the childhood process during which habitus is refined. Also, it has become more difficult to create questions in the context of current environments with diverse upbringing and family structures.

4. Conclusion, limitations, and future directions

This study generates an explanatory hypothesis about the essential nature of contemporary adventure tourists. This is due to the increasing number of adventurers based on diversity and the ambiguity of subjective experiences among adventurers, which make it challenging for tourism psychology approaches focused on motivations. Also, there is a lack of a conceptual framework for tourism operators, which reflects such adventure tourism without objective adventure elements due to risks and thrills. Hence, after referencing theories across academic disciplines that account for the subjective and intrinsic nature of adventure tourists seeking “transformation,” “learning,” and “expanded world-view,” a theory has been selected based on the verifiability. It is the explanatory hypothesis presented in Section 3.1. However, considering the alignment with grounded theories, which was widely referenced in the suggestive phase, it seems unnatural to categorically label them as adventure tourists who always seek self-transformation solely based on their individual capabilities. After considering the interaction between

given non-cognitive abilities and specific contexts, a formulation incorporating middle voice expressions, such as self-transformation and the resultant naturally elicited learning, would achieve better alignment with various theories. Therefore, the terminology was changed to modified explanatory hypothesis in section 3.2. The concept model presented in Fig. 3 illustrates how the adventure tourist, endowed with the value of being afforded the non-service ethnoscape and naturally invoking serendipity, can be applied as a marketable concept within the adventure tourism industry. This was foreshadowed by Beedie (2005) in his discussion of urban adventure tourism; true exploration is strongly linked to the uncertainties of outcome, and the more existing adventure tourism is commercialized, the newer territory (unknown places) will be explored, and adventure tourism will change.

However, these hypotheses are unobservable and are not a priori shared in the public domain. Therefore, as previously mentioned, separate empirical experiments are necessary. In this section, we discuss how the modified explanatory hypotheses can be validated through experimentation. As an example of experimental method, it would be appropriate to employ a structured questionnaire and participant observation in case study, and to select an analytical method that can show a strong explanatory model with a small number of samples while converting qualitative information into quantitative information, such as Qualitative Comparative Analysis (QCA), for the data collected.

Indeed, the choice of adopting a case study approach aligns with considerations of “middle-range theory” in the hypothesis setting. The ATTA survey, which has often been referred to as a data source in this study, targets adventure tourists in the United States and Australia as well as the adventure tourism driven by these Western tourists. Since they show a strong interest in culture, it is a more appropriate survey in areas where they can expect to experience different cultures. According to the Hokkaido District Transport Bureau (2019), Japan was the top destination of choice for adventure tourists from seven out of nine countries (Germany, UK, France, USA, Canada, Australia, Italy, Spain, and Russia, $n = 1800$). Adopting a case study in such a top country would make it easier to identify opportunities to survey adventure tourists.

Regarding the data collection, the survey is a structured questionnaire that measures the amount of non-cognitive abilities. This is a survey of effectivity or personal element. The scale for measuring non-cognitive ability confirms the mindset of the individual, which has no connection with the travel experience. However, this may not be the only major causal condition, and the presence of hidden confounding variables, such as affordance or environmental elements including interactions with guides and other guests and the presence or absence of ethnoscape encounters, might be overlooked. Therefore, it the researcher must visit the site of the experience, observe, and sometimes conduct interviews to predict the causal conditions in the environment wherein they create their subjective stories. The data thus collected should eventually be quantitatively tested to see how much they deviate from or approach the hypotheses, using analytical methods such as QCA developed by Ragin (1987), which depict a strong explanatory model despite the limited sample size.

Although the experimental method described above is limited to the region of the research study, it can suggest the non-cognitive abilities of adventure tourists to naturally generate serendipity in the region. If they are close to the behavioral characteristics of cross-boundary learners or entrepreneurs, the modified explanatory hypothesis can be said to be temporally true in the region. If this hypothesis is true, the adventure tourist will be a game changer, bringing a new marketing paradigm to the market. The areas where daily life, as it is, stays behind the development of servicescapes (off-the-beaten-track), will, on the contrary, generate economic potential. The role of the adventure tourism industry in future will not “develop” experiences and servicescapes, but “design” and “preserve” opportunities to encounter ethnoscares (“fields” where habitus can be exhibited, as described by Lahire (2012/2016).

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Yuma Akaho: Writing – original draft, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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